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Bold gamble, mixed verdict

Italians Sara Errani and Andrea Vavassori won the **revamped** mixed doubles tournament at the U. S. Open, though the new format didn't win over everyone.

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In February, when the US Tennis Association announced a revamped mixed doubles competition for this year's US Open, its CEO Lewis Sherr said the idea was to get more participation from singles players and grow the fan base around the world.

A shortened competition with only 16 teams, compared to the usual 32, was scheduled on August 19-20 to allow prominent singles players to pair up and play in the iconic Arthur Ashe Stadium and Louis Armstrong Stadium without compromising their main event, which began the following week.

The scoring format until the final was best-of-three sets played to four games, with a deciding point at deuce. Tiebreakers came at 4-all — rather than 6-6 in a regular match — and a 10-point match tiebreak replaced a third set.

For the summit clash, it was best-of-three sets played to six games with no-ad scoring, tiebreakers at 6-all, and a 10-point match tiebreaker.

The result?

Sara Errani and Andrea Vavassori, two doubles specialists from Italy, defended their title comfortably, beating six-time singles Major winner Iga Swiatek and three-time singles Grand Slam finalist Casper Ruud 6-3,

5-7, [10-6] in the final. Errani and Vavassori also pocketed one million USD, more than twice the total prize money that mixed doubles champions at the other three Slams received this year.

A statement by the United States Tennis Association (USTA) said: "The 2025 US Open Mixed Doubles Championship drew unprecedented crowds for a mixed doubles competition, with 78,000 fans visiting the grounds over August 19 and 20."

Putting mixed doubles into the spotlight in such a manner was a bold move, and it did catch people's attention. The US Open is known for taking such calls. Historically, it was the first Slam to introduce a final-set tiebreak, a shot clock between points, and in-game coaching.

However, the scheduling, the scoring format, the quality of play, as well as the entry criteria need to be reviewed if it wants to continue with its objective of popularising mixed doubles next year.

The event began less than 24 hours after the Cincinnati Open final, a gruelling 12-day Masters 1000 event. Carlos Alcaraz and Swiatek, the singles champions in Cincinnati, made it to New York just in time. However, World No. 1 Jannik Sinner, who was forced to retire after 20 minutes of the summit clash against Alcaraz due to illness, understandably withdrew. As a result, his partner and

doubles specialist Katerina Siniakova could compete neither in New York nor in either of the two WTA events taking place the same week.

Many other prominent singles players such as Aryna Sabalenka, Tommy Paul, and Emma Navarro, who had initially shown interest and were announced by the organisers as part of the lineup, also pulled out.

The scoring format was similar to the Next Gen ATP Finals, a season-ending exhibition tournament for the top eight men aged 20 and under. Should a Grand Slam, with a 144-year-old rich history and tradition, be treated like an exhibition event?

British No. 1 Jack Draper thought it was an exhibition. He paired up with USA's Jessica Pegula and beat the duos of Alcaraz and Emma Raducanu, and Daniil Medvedev and Mirra Andreeva to reach the semifinals on the first day. Later, in the press conference, Draper remarked, "Obviously, it is like a bit of an exhibition format," and Pegula, who could barely stop smiling, said, "You shouldn't be saying that, but that's okay."

A week before the event, Pegula had pointed out that the organisers did not take any feedback from the players regarding the change in format.

Coming to the list of 16 pairs, eight teams earned direct entry by their